

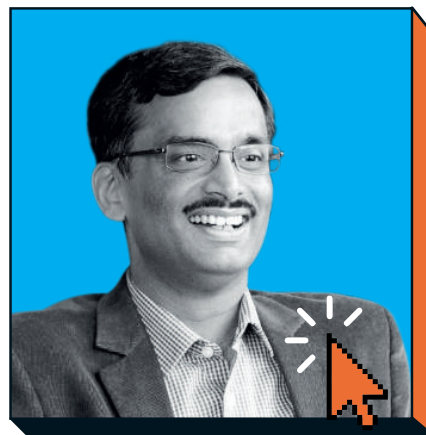
erbatating the need for skilling, upskilling and reskilling, L&D is certainly one of the crucial pieces in the lifecycle, say many. Darwinbox itself uses an external learning management system. “We’ve made a conscious choice not to develop one on our own because we believe it’s a specialised space and we are doing deep integrations on learning,” says Ananthanarayan. It’s quite common to find start-ups using each other’s offerings. Most of them, if not all, can be plugged into the existing HRMS of companies.

Meanwhile, a dozen and more start-ups are solving for the blue-collar space, which accounts for the lion’s share of the Indian workforce. Kunal Patil, CEO of blue- and grey-collar job search app WorkIndia, attributes it to the cheap data and smartphone revolution of 2017, which put internet into the palms of millions in the country, and the pandemic, which changed how people used their smartphones beyond just entertainment and for business and payments. “In India, there were 320 million smartphones in 2017 before Jio came in. Today, there are 720 million. Eighty per cent of this was driven by low-cost smartphones priced at ₹8,000-10,000, which are used by blue-collar workers.” The firm enables job seekers to call the employers directly instead of waiting for them to call back after applying.

BetterPlace’s Agarwala says the models may be the same as the ones for the white-collar workforce, but the nuances differ and solutions can’t be copy-pasted. “In white-collar, onboarding is almost two months long. In blue-collar, it happens in two hours and in a distributed environment. For example, a security guards’ firm we work with, operates in 2,000 sites across country. It’s a decentralised on-the-fly onboarding process,” he says.

Careernet’s Das cautions that blue-collar solutions may be harder to monetise because companies won’t shell out much per worker. But he estimates that a company’s overall dependence on third-party HR vendors has gone up from 25-30 per cent to 50 per cent (of the total HR function). Refyne’s Kumar doesn’t have an exact number for how many HR tech tools an organisation may be using today, but he says there are a few key elements everyone has to deal with—HRMS solutions, employee insurance, employee engagement and rewarding solutions. Ananthanarayan says Darwinbox has replaced giants like SAP’s Success Factors, Oracle or Workday in 150 cases.

“While many start-ups are mushrooming in this space, they fix a tiny problem in the entire hire-to-retain cycle. We do understand that no single vendor can own and solve every issue that a customer can require for their HR transformation. So, we have a unique innovation programme to work with start-ups,” says SAP’s Deodhar about Success Factors. He says their appeal among clients—enterprises and start-ups—also lies in being able



EVEN BEFORE THE PANDEMIC, A REASONABLE AMOUNT OF HR TECH WAS GETTING BUILT. AS REMOTE WORK AND HIRING PROVED TO BE EFFICIENT, COST-SAVING AND SCALEABLE, LOTS OF TECH STARTED GETTING BUILT IN VARIOUS AREAS IN HR

ANSHUMAN DAS
CEO & CO-FOUNDER, CAREERNET

to manage the law beyond India. Rival Oracle launched a new employee experience platform, Oracle ME, in April. Asia Pacific Vice President (HCM) Deepa Param Singhla says, “Our differentiation factor has always been the kind of industry insights we procure and implement for our solutions,” adding that Airtel has transformed all its internal processes with Oracle’s portfolio.

TRIDENT’S LUTHRA says the immediate problem start-ups are able to solve is making the processes seamlessly digital. “Take interviewing platforms. They are definitely fulfilling a gap without compromising on the candidate experience. Only research will tell us the validity and viability of some of their assessments, but it improves the experience for sure,” says Luthra. Besides, they are more flexible and agile than legacy firms, she adds. “When it’s time for objectives and key results (OKRs), they are quick to change the look and feel of the product. Something like Success Factors, which is a part of a larger organisation, tends to be slower in adapting and customisation. But the start-ups